

Question 41 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Explain the concept of Training Needs Assessment (TNA) and state its importance in HRD.

Introduction

Training Needs Assessment, also called Training Needs Analysis, is Stage 1 of the four-stage training cycle in the notes: (1) TNA, (2) planning and design, (3) implementing/delivery, (4) evaluating. TNA is the systematic study of whether people need training, who needs it, in what, and whether training is even the right solution.

A simple formula in the notes is: Training and development need = Standard performance – Actual performance. A beginner must add a warning: this formula is true only when the cause of the gap is lack of knowledge, skill or attitude. If the machine is broken, the target is impossible, or the person is not paid, that is not a training need. The notes say the cause-and-effect problem analysis should first be applied before deciding whether training is the answer. They also warn against buying ‘off the shelf’ programmes without checking relevance.

Detailed points

- 1. Organisation analysis — first layer of the concept.** There must be a link between the firm’s strategies/goals and training. Organisation analysis asks: where is performance hurting our goals? Will the culture and bosses support training? Are we about to close a product line (then do not train extra people for it)? This layer stops HRD from becoming a private hobby of the training cell.
- 2. Task analysis — second layer.** This identifies the important tasks of the job and the knowledge, skills and attitudes (KSA) that must be emphasised so employees can complete those tasks. Example: for a complaint-handling job, tasks include listening, logging in software, offering a solution, escalating. Each task has KSAs. Task analysis produces the skeleton of content.
- 3. Person analysis — third layer.** Compare required KSAs with what each employee actually has. This answers who should attend. Two people with the same job title may not have the same gap: a new joiner needs basics; a veteran may need only an update. Person analysis also finds ‘knows but does not do’ — which may be motivation or climate, not training.
- 4. Importance — relevance and stopping waste.** TNA prevents off-the-shelf waste. Training money and employee time are scarce. Irrelevant programmes also make employees cynical about HRD, which damages climate. Importance is therefore financial and cultural.
- 5. Importance — honest diagnosis.** TNA protects HRD’s professional honesty. If errors come from a bad incentive to rush, a course on ‘quality awareness’ will fail and management will still say ‘we already trained them’. Importance: the right problem is named.
- 6. Importance — design quality.** Objectives, difficulty level, examples, and method (on-the-job vs classroom vs e-learning) all come from TNA. Without TNA, design is decoration on a guess.
- 7. Importance — fairness and priority.** Critical jobs and large gaps first. Person analysis supports equity: those who need help get it, not only people close to the boss. This matches HRD’s equity objective.
- 8. Importance — evaluation baseline.** You cannot know if training worked unless you knew the starting gap and what success would look like. TNA writes the criteria that Kirkpatrick evaluation later uses. Without baseline, anyone can claim success.

Conclusion. Define TNA as systematic identification of whether, who and what to train, using organisation, task and person analysis, after checking that the gap is really a KSA gap. Importance: relevance, honest diagnosis, better design, fairness, priority, and a baseline for evaluation. TNA is the foundation of professional training in HRD; skipping it makes the other three stages guesswork.